

Paper Title

Author Name

Abstract—

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I. INTRODUCTION

Deep learning has achieved strong performance in many radar applications, including target detection, classification, and recognition. Its performance, however, depends strongly on the quantity, diversity, and annotation quality of the available data. This dependence is particularly restrictive for maritime radar because existing measured datasets cover only a limited set of sea states, radar parameters, viewing geometries, and target conditions. A model trained on such data may not generalize to an unobserved wind speed, wave direction, grazing angle, or clutter regime. Expanding a measured dataset is also difficult: sea experiments require suitable platforms, radar equipment, environmental sensors, synchronized observations, and favorable weather, while a desired sea condition cannot be reproduced on demand. The shortage and limited diversity of measured radar data have therefore become a major constraint on the development of data-driven maritime sensing methods.

Numerical simulation provides a practical way to supplement measured data because environmental and radar parameters can be controlled independently and a large number of labeled samples can be generated repeatedly. For radar applications, however, computational efficiency alone is insufficient. A simulated sea surface must preserve the statistical roughness of the background sea, respond reasonably to different wind and wave conditions, and represent the local structures that produce strong or non-Gaussian radar returns. High-fidelity hydrodynamic methods can resolve nonlinear wave evolution and breaking interfaces in detail, while full-wave electromagnetic methods can describe the associated diffraction and multipath interactions. Their volume-mesh evolution, fine spatial discretization, or global electromagnetic interactions nevertheless impose substantial computational and storage costs, making repeated simulation over many environmental and radar conditions difficult. Spectral sea-surface and facet-based scattering models are considerably more efficient, but a conventional linear realization does not explicitly represent strongly nonlinear or overturning crests. A useful data-generation method must therefore balance physical credibility, environmental adaptability, computational cost, and compatibility with radar scattering calculations.

Sea-surface roughness is inherently multiscale. Long gravity waves determine the large-scale tilt and motion of the surface, whereas shorter wind waves modify local slopes and radar-resonant components. Consequently, the observed return depends jointly on sea state, incidence angle, radar wavelength, and surface geometry. High-resolution measurements show that sea clutter may exhibit pronounced non-Gaussian tails

and intermittent sea spikes, which can be confused with target responses [?], [?], [?], [?], [?]. Directional wave spectra, such as the unified Elfouhaily spectrum, provide an efficient description of the gravity and gravity-capillary energy distribution [?]. Nevertheless, a linear spectral realization is approximately Gaussian and mainly preserves second-order statistics. Nonlinear hydrodynamic interactions sharpen crests, smooth troughs, and change the distributions of slopes and curvatures, thereby influencing the scattering coefficient and Doppler spectrum [?]. The sea-surface skewness function and its small-scale-wave parameter also affect the upwind-downwind asymmetry of radar backscattering [?], while convolutions of short-wave spectral components can contribute appreciably to the normalized backscattering cross section under different radar frequencies, wind speeds, and incidence angles [?]. Thus, a radar-oriented sea model should represent not only the total spectral energy but also nonlinear crest geometry and the directional organization of shorter wind waves.

The return from an ordinary rough sea surface is commonly described by quasi-specular, Bragg, or two-scale scattering formulations. Their relative contributions vary with incidence angle, and both quasi-specular and Bragg mechanisms may be required in the transition range [?]. Radar observations of marine film slicks further suggest that the source of short wind waves can depend on propagation direction and cannot always be represented by conventional wind-input terms alone [?]. For steep and breaking waves, additional scattering mechanisms become important. Numerical and experimental studies have related low-grazing-angle sea spikes to steepening or breaking crests [?], [?], [?]. Full-wave and hybrid models have investigated crest diffraction, rough-face scattering, and multipath interactions [?], [?], [?], [?], [?]. Facet-based methods have introduced breaking-wave contributions into larger sea surfaces and analyzed their effects on normalized radar cross section (NRCS), sea spikes, and synthetic aperture radar images [?]. Three-dimensional plunging-breaker models combined with ray tracing have also shown that a breaker crest can generate target-like peaks in radar cross section and high-resolution range profiles [?].

Existing reduced-order sea-surface models avoid part of the cost of coupled hydrodynamic and full-wave electromagnetic simulation, but they do not fully satisfy the requirements of radar dataset generation. Linear spectral methods efficiently generate large random surfaces and reproduce prescribed second-order wave statistics, but they cannot describe crest-trough asymmetry or overturning breaker geometry. Nonlinear transformations improve crest sharpness, slope, and higher-order statistics, yet the resulting surface is commonly retained as a single-valued height function and therefore cannot explicitly form a curling lip or an overhanging face. Breaker-

replacement and prescribed-profile methods introduce a measured, numerical, or analytically parameterized breaker into a background surface and are useful for investigating localized scattering mechanisms [?], [?], [?], [?]. However, the breaker location, scale, orientation, and development stage are often specified separately from the surrounding random wind-wave field. A fixed or independently parameterized template may represent only a limited set of sea conditions, may not respond continuously to changes in wind speed and direction, and may disturb the spectral energy or slope statistics of the background surface when it is inserted directly. Similarly, simply superposing an additional short-wave component can duplicate energy in the selected band and does not guarantee a physically consistent dominant propagation direction. Consequently, the remaining problem is not only computational efficiency, but also how to generate sea surfaces that are statistically consistent, geometrically credible, flexibly controlled by environmental conditions, and directly usable for radar simulation within one unified framework.

This letter proposes a hierarchical sea-surface simulation method intended for rapid radar-data generation under variable environmental conditions. First, an Elfouhaily directional spectrum and a wind-dependent nonlinear Lie transformation are used to construct a statistically constrained nonlinear background surface. Second, a selected short-wave band is replaced by an equal-energy directional component, forming shorter wind-wave ridges with a prescribed dominant propagation direction without repeatedly injecting spectral energy. Third, candidate crests are identified from elevation, propagation-direction slope, and curvature, after which a compactly supported coordinate transformation generates a localized forward-extending and downward-curling breaker. Wind speed, wind direction, directional spreading, short-wave scale, and local curling parameters can be varied to produce different sea-surface realizations, while the facet representation allows the generated surfaces to be used directly in radar scattering and echo simulations. Because the nonlinear and curling operations are applied through spectral and sparse local surface updates, the method avoids repeated three-dimensional fluid evolution and dense full-wave interaction for every generated realization. It is therefore designed to retain radar-relevant breaker geometry while remaining suitable for large, controllable synthetic radar datasets.

The method is evaluated from surface geometry to radar observables and computational scalability. The background and short-wave-enriched surfaces are first examined using spectral consistency and along-wind and crosswind mean-square slopes under different wind conditions. The localized breaker is then assessed using crest geometry, facet-orientation statistics, radar-facing projected area, and paired unit-footprint scattering enhancement. Radar echoes generated from the complete surface are evaluated through range-time intensity, temporal correlation, and amplitude-distribution statistics. Finally, the measured runtime is decomposed into surface generation, facet-level scattering, echo formation, and input/output costs; its scaling with surface resolution and dataset size is compared with reported X-band numerical methods, with differences in output scope stated explicitly [?], [?], [?].

Section II presents the hierarchical surface model. Section III describes the validation metrics and radar echo generation. Section IV reports the surface and radar comparisons. Section V analyzes computational cost and dataset scalability, and Section VI concludes this letter.

REFERENCES